

# Plants for contemporary perennial designs

Contemporary perennial designs focus on tough, hardy perennials and grasses that are combined to form waves of color and texture.

When creating your own scheme, use a limited palette of species and knit together large swaths of contrasting heights and shapes to produce beautiful patterns. Although this planting style tends to suit big gardens, it can work in smaller spaces if you reduce the number of species but still plant in large groups. Try “see-through” plants like purpletop vervain toward the front of your scheme, and include key plant shapes, such as flat-topped yarrow, spiky salvia, and daisy-like coneflower, together with a few grasses for foliage interest. Leave the seedheads and stems to stand over winter, then cut them down in early spring.



PERENNIAL LARGE

## *Achillea filipendulina*

**YARROW** An upright perennial with deeply divided pale green leaves and dense domed flower heads of tightly packed yellow, daisy-like summer flowers. The blooms can be left to dry for fall color; also good for cutting or drying indoors.

↑4½ft (1.4m) ↔24in (60cm)

☀ Z3–8



PERENNIAL LARGE

## *Actaea racemosa*

**BLACK COHOSH** This upright perennial has deeply divided leaves, above which branched bottlebrush spikes of white flowers form in midsummer. The dried brown seedheads are also attractive. Grow it at the rear of a bed.

↑5ft (1.5m) ↔24in (60cm)

☀ Z3–8 (N)



PERENNIAL LARGE

## *Actaea simplex*

**BUGBANE** This upright perennial has divided foliage and white-tinged purple bottlebrush flowers in fall. Plant with contrasting green-leaved perennials in shade or behind sun-lovers. Purple-leaved ‘Brunette’ (above) is popular.

↑4ft (1.2m) ↔24in (60cm)

☀ Z4–8



PERENNIAL LARGE

## *Agastache foeniculum*

**ANISE HYSOP** This upright perennial has leaves that smell and taste of licorice. Plant it in swaths toward the front of a bed to show off its spikes of fluffy lavender-blue summer flowers, which are attractive to bees and butterflies.

↑4ft (1.2m) ↔12in (30cm)

☀ Z4–9 (N)



BULB LARGE

## *Allium* ‘Purple Sensation’

**FLOWERING ONION** This perennial bulb produces sturdy stems topped with spherical heads of purple flowers in early summer. Plant the bulbs in groups in fall between perennials that will disguise the leaves, which fade as the flowers appear.

↑32in (80cm)

☀ Z3–8



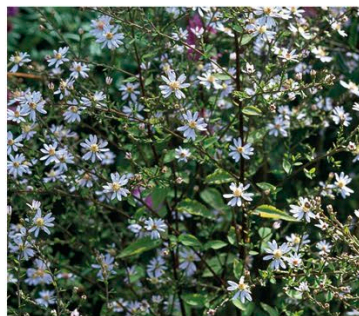
ANNUAL/BIENNIAL LARGE

## *Angelica archangelica*

**ANGELICA** A tall biennial with an upright, branching habit and large deeply cut, decorative green leaves. It forms a clump of foliage in the first year and flowers the next, bearing domed heads of tiny green blooms during summer. It self-seeds freely.

↑6ft (2m) ↔3ft (1m)

☀ Z4–8



PERENNIAL LARGE

## *Aster cordifolius*

**Renamed *Symphyotrichum cordifolium***

This blue wood aster produces small leaves and, from late summer to fall, sprays of blue-tinted white daisy-like flowers that add color and texture toward the rear of a bed.

↑4ft (1.2m) ↔18in (45cm)

☀ Z3–8 (N)



PERENNIAL MEDIUM

## *Astilbe x ardensii* ‘Fanal’

**ASTILBE** This perennial has broad green leaves divided into smaller leaflets and upright, tapering feathery heads of tiny, crimson summer flowers, which turn brown and keep their shape in winter. It is ideal for boggy areas and pond margins.

↑24in (60cm) ↔18in (45cm)

☀ Z3–8



PERENNIAL LARGE

## *Calamagrostis brachytricha*

**KOREAN FEATHER REED GRASS** An upright deciduous grass with arching gray-green leaves that turn straw-colored in winter and tall feather-shaped pink-tinted silver flower heads. Use it as a backdrop to colorful blooms from summer to fall.

↑4½ft (1.4m) ↔20in (50cm)

☀ Z4–9